DREAM WALKER

Game Design Document

Version 1.2 | Solo Developer | Unity 6.2

Game Overview

Genre	3D Isometric Action Adventure
Engine	Unity 6.2 (URP)
Platform	PC (Windows / Mac) -- Controller and Keyboard/Mouse
Target Rating	T for Teen (themes of mental health)
Art Style	Low poly 3D -- Death's Door aesthetic: dark, dreamlike, desaturated world with selective warm lighting
Audio	FMOD adaptive audio (implementation deferred)
Solo Dev	Narrative Design, Systems Design, Unity Development

Dream Walker is a 3D isometric action game about a cat who enters a girl's dream world to fight the psychological weight that has been slowly pulling her under. Her mental health conditions have been stripping her life down piece by piece. She stopped sleeping properly. Stopped eating. Let go of the things she used to love. She found the cat in an alley one rainy night on her way home from a particularly bad day. She brought her inside. She did not know the cat is a dream walker.

Art Direction & Tone

Visual Reference: Death's Door

Dream Walker takes its visual language directly from Death's Door. The principles:

- 3D world with a locked orthographic isometric camera -- never rotates, player moves through it
- Low poly geometry with hard edges and flat or near-flat shading -- no tiny details, everything reads as silhouette first
- Desaturated world palette -- the dream is drained of colour except where the cat brings it
- Selective warm lighting -- the cat carries a warm point light. Everything meaningful is warm. Everything threatening is cold.
- URP post-processing -- bloom on lights, cold colour grading, vignette, subtle ambient occlusion

THE CORE VISUAL RULE
The cat is warmth. The dream world is cold. Every lighting and colour decision in the game follows from this single principle. Warm means safe, alive, meaningful. Cold means threatening, empty, heavy. This is the emotional language of the game rendered in light.

Per-Night Colour Identity

Night 01 -- Depression	Near-black ambient. Cold blue-green shadows. The cat's gold light is the only warmth. Fog density 0.08.
Night 02 -- Anxiety	Purple-tinted ambient. The cat's light flickers. Paths feel unstable. Higher vignette intensity.
Night 03 -- CPTSD	Desaturated with occasional flashes of colour tied to trauma objects. The world remembers things.
Night 04 -- ADHD	Time distortion affects lighting -- slow motion makes everything dim and heavy, haste makes it overexposed.
Waking World	Warm, soft, open. No vignette. Higher ambient. Reality should feel gentle compared to the dream.

Core Concept

The Premise

A girl's mental health conditions have been quietly dismantling her life. Not all at once. Just slowly, steadily, taking things from her. Her sleep. Her appetite. Her hobbies. Her sense of herself. She is aware of what is happening and that awareness does not help.

One rainy night coming home from a terrible day at work, she finds a cat in an alley and takes her home. What she does not know is that the cat is a dream walker. She can enter the space between waking and sleep and fight what lives there. Each night corresponds to one of the girl's conditions. Each boss is a manifestation of something real. The cat goes in because she is able to, and because somebody should.

THE TONE
Dream Walker is a narrative action RPG about fighting for someone who cannot fight for themselves yet. The cat carries no personal stake in the dream world beyond caring about the girl. That distinction shapes everything: her voice, her movement, how she responds to what she finds. The conditions are treated with specificity. The Specter of Depression does not rush or rage. It drifts. It drains. It absorbs every hit without reacting. The mechanic is the message.

Player Character -- The Cat

Character Overview

The cat does not speak in the waking world. In the dream she has a full voice: warm and fierce, protective without being precious about it. She has been in places like this before. She is not rattled by the Specter. She is just there to do what needs doing and she knows how.

The fact that she is fighting for someone else shapes everything about her. She is not afraid because it is not her pain. She can look at it clearly. That is the gift she brings.

Movement & Controls

Move	Left stick (controller) / WASD (keyboard) -- isometric directions
Face	Left stick direction controls facing -- cat always faces where she moves
Dash	Right Shoulder (controller) / Space (keyboard) -- brief invincibility frames

Melee Attack	Square / Button West (controller) / Left Mouse (keyboard)
Light Attack	Triangle / Button North (controller) / E (keyboard)
Pause	Start (controller) / Escape (keyboard)

CONTROLLER FIRST
Dream Walker is designed controller-first. All feel decisions are made for analog input. Keyboard/mouse is a fully supported fallback. Key remapping is built in from the start Key remapping is planned as an accessibility feature built on the new Unity Input System.

Combat Systems

Melee Attack

Left click / Square. Activates a sphere collider hitbox in front of the cat for 0.12 seconds. 25 damage per hit. 0.35 second cooldown. One swing cannot hit the same enemy twice. On hit: triggers hitstop (0.07s at 0.04x timescale) and screen shake via Cinemachine Impulse. Both are independently toggleable accessibility options.

Light Attack -- Long Range Projectile

E / Triangle. Costs 20 light. Fires a light projectile in the direction the cat faces. Projectile travels at speed 15, deals 60 damage on contact, lifetime 3 seconds. The light mechanic is the resource system -- the cat must collect light orbs to fuel her ranged attack.

Dash

Space / Right Shoulder. Dashes in current movement direction (forward if standing still). Duration 0.18s at speed 20. Grants invincibility frames for the full dash duration. 0.75 second cooldown. Visual feedback: cat renderer flashes during iframes.

The Light Mechanic

The cat carries a warm point light everywhere she goes. In a world that is almost entirely dark, that light is the game's central visual and the resource system at the same time.

Light orbs scattered through each night. Walking into one adds 20 light to the pool, capped at 100. Each light attack costs 20, so five shots maximum before needing to collect more. A gold bar in the UI tracks the level.

Orb placement is intentional. Dead ends have orbs in them because exploration should feel worth it. The boss arena has orbs in it because standing still should not be an option. Running out of light has weight.

DESIGN INTENT

The light mechanic is the game refusing to let the player be passive.
It rewards exploration. It creates movement pressure in boss fights.
The cat brought light into this place. She has to keep earning it.

Narrative System

Ink Integration

All dialogue and narrative text is written in Ink (inkle Studios) and integrated via the ink-unity-integration package. Story content lives in .ink files outside the codebase, making it editable without touching Unity.

Three Narrative Layers

1. Ambient Monologue

The cat comments on the environment as she moves through it. Triggered automatically by proximity to specific areas or objects. Displayed as floating world-space text near the trigger point. These are observations, not exposition -- she notices things.

2. Memory Interactions

Physical objects scattered through the dream world that the player can interact with. Each has associated Ink dialogue. The cat can interact with the same object multiple times -- her response may change based on game state. Displayed as world-space text.

3. Dialogue Exchanges

Conversations with significant entities -- primarily the bosses before combat. Displayed as a bottom-screen text box with speaker name. Player clicks through at their own pace. The Specter exchange before the Night 01 boss fight is the primary example.

THE CAT'S VOICE IN THE DREAM

The cat does not speak in the waking world. In the dream she has a voice.
Her tone is: warm, fierce, protective. She is not afraid. She is not processing her own pain.
She is there for the girl. Every line she speaks should come from that place.
She knows what the Specter is. She is not surprised. She is just there to end it.

Night Structure

Dream Walker has four nights plus a Waking World hub. Each night is a self-contained scene with its own environment, enemy set, boss, and psychological theme. Completing a night changes the Waking World.

Night 01 -- Depression

Theme	Depression -- the absence of warmth, the weight of emptiness
Environment	Dense dark forest. Near-zero ambient light. Cold blue-green shadows.
Enemy	SlowShadow -- patrols slowly, chases when player is close, drains health via aura damage. Does not rush. Does not react to hits. It just keeps coming.
Boss	The Specter -- drifts toward the player always. No stagger. No knockback. Absorbs hits with only a subtle light pulse. Grows at 50% health. Phase 2 increases speed and aura radius.
Mechanic	Darkness as presence. The cat's light is the only warmth. Orbs in dead ends reward exploration.
Waking World Change	Dirty dishes disappear. A window opens. Small signs of life returning.

Night 02 -- Anxiety

Theme	Anxiety -- fragmentation, hypervigilance, the inability to rest
Environment	Purple-tinted. Cat's light flickers. Paths feel unstable.
Enemy	FractureEnemy -- splits into fragments on hit. Fragments regenerate unless killed with a light attack. Rewards the player for saving light resource.
Boss	TBD -- anxiety manifests as something that multiplies under pressure
Mechanic	Resource management under pressure. The player must decide when to spend light.
Waking World Change	TBD

Night 03 -- CPTSD

Theme	CPTSD -- trauma as physical presence, memory as environment

Environment	Desaturated with trauma objects embedded in the world -- a wrecked car, picture frames facing away.
Enemy	TBD
Boss	The Mimic -- cycles through forms matching trauma objects. Only vulnerable in specific ways per form.
Mechanic	Recognition and response. The player learns to read which form the Mimic is in.
Waking World Change	TBD

Night 04 -- ADHD

Theme	ADHD -- time distortion, hyperfocus, the inability to regulate pace
Environment	TBD
Enemy	TBD
Boss	The Time Mage -- shifts Time.timeScale between Slow (0.4x), Normal (1x), and Haste (1.8x) at random intervals. Always restores timeScale on death.
Mechanic	Adapting to unpredictable rhythm. The player cannot control the pace -- only respond to it.
Waking World Change	Final state -- the apartment feels lived in again.

The Waking World

Between nights the game returns to the girl's apartment. The cat is there. So is the girl. After each night beaten, something small has shifted in her. She picked up a hobby she abandoned. She made herself a real meal instead of skipping it. The apartment is the same space, but it feels a little more inhabited each time.

The cat notices these things. She interacts with the girl and with the small changes in the space. These exchanges are not exposition. They are just the two of them in an apartment at whatever hour it is, the dream behind them, the girl a little bit more present than she was before.

Visually the waking world is intentionally warmer and more open than the dream. Higher ambient light, no vignette, softer post-processing. Coming back here should feel like exhaling.

After a moment the game proceeds to the next night. The player cannot stay but they have enough time to take in what changed.

Accessibility

Accessibility has been a design consideration from the start, not an afterthought. The game is about mental health. Its players may well be people living with the conditions it depicts. That matters.

Implemented

- Screen shake toggle: independently disables Cinemachine Impulse screen shake
- Hitstop toggle: independently disables the time freeze on hit
- Settings accessible from both title screen and pause menu
- Settings persist between sessions via PlayerPrefs
- Save anywhere except during active boss fights. Boss rooms are checkpoints: players respawn outside the arena on death.
- Continue button on the title screen greyed out when no save exists rather than hidden
- Controller and keyboard/mouse both fully supported

Planned

- Key/button remapping UI: foundation built on new Unity Input System
- Reduced motion option
- Font size options for dialogue text
- Colorblind-friendly palette options
- Subtitle/caption support for any audio narrative

Technical Architecture

Engine & Packages

Engine	Unity 6.2 (6000.2.x) -- Universal Render Pipeline
Cinemachine	Version 3.x -- locked isometric camera, Impulse screen shake
AI Navigation	Version 2.0 -- NavMesh Surface workflow for enemy pathfinding
Input System	New Unity Input System -- DreamWalkerControls Input Action Asset
Narrative	Ink + ink-unity-integration -- all story content in .ink files
Audio	FMOD Studio -- deferred, planned for Month 5
Version Control	Git via GitHub Desktop -- private repository

Core Systems Built

CatController	CharacterController-based movement, dash with iframes, facing direction, FixedUpdate driven
CameraFollow	CameraTarget parented to Cat, Cinemachine Follow tracks it with damping
AttackHitbox	Sphere trigger on Cat child, HashSet prevents multi-hit per swing
EnemyBase	Inheritance base for all enemies -- health, damage, hit flash, death sequence
EnemyID	Unique string ID per enemy, registers permanent death with save system
HitEffects	Singleton -- hitstop via timeScale, screen shake via CinemachineImpulseSource. Both independently toggleable.
LightManager	Singleton -- tracks light resource, AddLight/UseLight/SetLight
CatHealth	Health with iframes check, death triggers DeathScreen
LightOrb	Bob/rotate pickup, adds to LightManager on trigger
LightProjectile	Travels in launch direction, damages EnemyBase on trigger
SlowShadow	NavMeshAgent enemy -- patrol/chase state machine, aura damage
Specter	Boss -- always chasing, phase 2 at 50% health, no stagger, light pulse on hit

GameState	DontDestroyOnLoad singleton -- night completion, save/load via PlayerPrefs
SaveLoader	Restores player position, health, and light from save data on scene load
HUDController	Drives health bar, light bar, boss health bar (hides when boss is dead)
DeathScreen	Disables player input, shows panel, reloads scene
PauseMenu	Escape key -- Resume, Settings sub-panel, Save, Quit
TitleScreenController	Start, Continue (greyed if no save), Settings, Quit
DialogueManager	Reads Ink story, parses speaker tags, click-to-advance, pauses game
DialogueTrigger	Collider-based trigger, fires once, starts DialogueManager
SettingsSaver	Reads/writes accessibility settings to PlayerPrefs on change and quit

Scope & Development Status

Dream Walker is a solo portfolio project. Four nights, four bosses, one complete loop. The goal right now is a solid Night 01 that works from start to finish before building out the rest.

Current Status

- Night 01 core loop playable from title screen through Specter defeat
- All core systems implemented and functional
- Greybox placeholder geometry throughout, no final art
- No audio yet, FMOD integration deferred
- Narrative system built, dialogue content not yet written

Immediate Next Steps

- Level design for Night 01: room structure, puzzle gates, boss arena
- Write Specter dialogue in Ink
- Build WakingWorld scene
- Scene fade transition
- Find or commission a low poly cat model: rigged, animated, no built-in movement controller
- Environment art: low poly dark forest asset kit

Team Needs

- 3D Artist: cat character model (rigged, low poly, Death's Door aesthetic), enemy models, environment kit
- Level Designer: optional depending on what the environment art kit provides

The cat chose her. You chose this.